

THE HILL

Episode 2 — “The Chicken Dinner”

Script Draft — Act Two

Version 0.1 Continued

ACT TWO

INT. HORNER HOUSE — MIDDAY

The family remains frozen around the table.

The food is still there.

Chicken cooling.

Bread torn but unfinished.

Beans untouched in the bowl.

Christopher looks from face to face.

CHRISTOPHER

Are we done?

No one answers.

Mary Ann slowly reaches for him and pulls him closer.

William stands near the doorway, listening.

Spencer stays by the table.

His hand rests on the back of his chair.

He wants to move.

He wants to do something.

Doing something feels dangerous.

Doing nothing feels worse.

PERMELIA

Sit down.

Spencer looks at her.

PERMELIA (CONT'D)

If they wanted us now, they'd be here.

William does not look away from the door.

WILLIAM

Unless they want us tired.

Permelia absorbs that.

No one likes how much sense it makes.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — MIDDAY

The yard is empty.

A plate sits near the doorway where Mary Ann had carried it and forgotten it.

Flies gather.

The field beyond the yard is still.

The potato patch.

The open ground.

The wooded hillside.

All of it waiting.

Above, the ridge road is hidden by trees.

A horse snorts somewhere out of sight.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

John Samuel stands beside the window.

Not directly in front of it.

Beside it.

He has learned angles.

William sees this.

A quiet pain crosses his face.

WILLIAM

Come away from there.

JOHN SAMUEL

I can see without them seeing.

WILLIAM

You don't know that.

JOHN SAMUEL

Neither do you.

The answer cuts the room open.

Spencer looks at John Samuel — really looks at him.

A child speaking like a man because the men have run out of certainty.

SPENCER

Come sit.

John Samuel does not.

Not defiance.

Need.

JOHN SAMUEL

Somebody has to know if they move.

Spencer has no answer.

Permelia does.

PERMELIA
Then stand lower.

John Samuel lowers himself slightly.

Mary Ann looks at Permelia.

That was not permission.

That was survival.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

Jess Wilson crouches beside the road.

Not dramatic.

Practical.

He studies the ground where riders have shifted in and out of the timber.

The borrowed auger lies beside him.

The second rider watches the house through a gap in the trees.

SECOND RIDER
Old man still inside?

JESS
Mostly.

SECOND RIDER
Son?

JESS
Door.

SECOND RIDER
Boy?

Jess looks again.

Through the window: the small shape of John Samuel.

JESS
Watching.

The second rider spits.

SECOND RIDER
Children watch too much.

Jess picks up the auger.

JESS
Only when grown men give them reason.

The second rider looks at him.

For one brief second, Jess sounds almost human.

Then it passes.

EXT. SMALL ROAD BELOW RIDGE — AFTERNOON

The local man from Act One moves west with his mule, away from the Horner place.

He looks back once.

He can still see the smoke from the chimney through the trees.

He stops.

His conscience almost wins.

Then he hears riders somewhere behind him.

He lowers his head.

Keeps moving west.

The show does not condemn him loudly.

It lets the choice sit.

Fear is part of the county now.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — DAY

Daniel's notes.

FEAR MOVES TOO.

Beside it, he writes:

THE ONES WHO SAW AND DID NOT WARN

He stops.

Crosses out DID NOT.

Writes instead:

COULD NOT / WOULD NOT / WERE AFRAID TO

Daniel does not let the record become too simple.

DANIEL (V.O.)

It is easy, from a safe century, to ask why no one warned them.

A pause.

DANIEL (V.O.)

The harder question is what kind of county makes warning dangerous.

He looks at the blankness around the known names.

DANIEL (V.O.)

The record keeps the dead better than it keeps the frightened.

Cut back.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — AFTERNOON

Mary Ann clears the table because leaving food out feels like surrender.

Her hands move automatically.

Plate.

Cup.

Knife.

Bowl.

She reaches for William's plate.

He has barely eaten.

MARY ANN
You need food.

WILLIAM
I need eyes.

MARY ANN
You need both.

He looks at her.

A small domestic truth in the middle of terror.

He takes a bite from the plate while standing.

Chews without tasting.

Mary Ann watches him swallow.

That is love now.

Not words.

Making sure he swallows.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATER

Spencer sits with the rifle across his lap.

The room is too still.

Christopher is restless.

CHRISTOPHER

Can I go out?

MARY ANN

No.

CHRISTOPHER

Can I sit by the door?

MARY ANN

No.

CHRISTOPHER

Can I—

PERMELIA

Christopher.

He stops.

His small face collapses.

Not crying.

Trying not to.

John Samuel sees it.

He moves from the window and sits beside Christopher.

JOHN SAMUEL

Here.

He gives Christopher the scrap of wood.

Christopher takes it.

CHRISTOPHER

You don't want it?

JOHN SAMUEL

I seen it already.

Christopher studies the wood like that makes sense.

John Samuel looks back toward the window.

He gave up the toy.

Not the watch.

EXT. FIELD EDGE — AFTERNOON

William steps outside.

Just outside.

Spencer follows before anyone can stop him.

WILLIAM
Get back in.

SPENCER
Don't talk to me like I'm one of the boys.

WILLIAM
Then don't walk out where they can count you.

Spencer stops.

The words land.

Count you.

From above, the house is numbers:

one old man
one son
two women
two boys

Spencer looks toward the ridge.

SPENCER
You think Jess is up there.

WILLIAM
I think somebody is.

SPENCER
That ain't what I asked.

A beat.

William decides to say it.

WILLIAM

Yes.

Spencer absorbs the name.

It hurts because it is not surprising enough.

SPENCER

He borrowed from me.

WILLIAM

I know.

SPENCER

I gave it to him.

WILLIAM

I know.

Spencer's face tightens.

Not with anger.

With humiliation.

SPENCER

A man ought to be able to lend a tool.

William looks toward the ridge.

WILLIAM

A man ought to be able to eat at his table.

That ends it.

They go back inside.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — SAME

Jess watches them disappear back into the house.

The auger rests across his saddle now.

The second rider studies Jess.

SECOND RIDER

You know him too well.

Jess does not answer.

SECOND RIDER (CONT'D)

That gonna be a problem?

Jess looks down at the house.

JESS

It already is.

A beat.

The second rider smiles faintly.

SECOND RIDER

For him.

Jess does not smile.

JESS

For everybody.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — LATE AFTERNOON

The light changes.

Gold again.

Like Act Four of Episode 1.

The chicken dinner is gone now.

Only bones.

Scraps.

Grease on plates.

The last normal meal has already happened.

Nobody knows what to do with the rest of the day.

Permelia wraps leftover bread.

Mary Ann cleans the knife.

Spencer looks older than he did in the morning.

William stands by the door again.

John Samuel watches him.

JOHN SAMUEL
You think they'll wait till dark?

William considers lying.

Does not.

WILLIAM
Maybe.

JOHN SAMUEL
Or morning?

William looks at him.

WILLIAM
Maybe.

JOHN SAMUEL
That ain't knowing.

William's voice softens.

WILLIAM
No.

A beat.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
It ain't.

John Samuel nods.

The honesty steadies him more than comfort would have.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — LATE AFTERNOON

A crow lands on the fence.

It looks toward the house.

Then toward the field.

A second crow lands.

Then both lift suddenly and fly off.

No music.

Just wings.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — SAME

Everyone hears the birds lift.

William steps to the doorway.

Spencer rises.

Permelia grips the table.

Mary Ann gathers Christopher close.

John Samuel moves low toward the window.

Nothing.

The yard is still.

William breathes out through his nose.

WILLIAM
Birds.

SPENCER

Birds don't spook for nothing.

William looks at him.

For once, Spencer is learning the new rules.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — LATE AFTERNOON

Fate not yet.

Wash not yet.

Only ordinary men becoming something worse.

Jess, the second rider, and two others remain in timber.

One of the other riders is younger.

Barely more than a boy.

He looks sick.

YOUNG RIDER

There's children.

SECOND RIDER

Children grow.

YOUNG RIDER

That ain't an answer.

SECOND RIDER

Wasn't meant to be.

Jess hears them.

Does not turn.

The young rider looks down at the house and cannot stop looking.

The show lets us see that violence is made by men, not monsters.

That makes it worse.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — EVENING

The light is fading.

Spencer stands.

SPENCER

We won't sit here all night jumping at birds.

PERMELIA

What you fixing to do?

SPENCER

Step out.

MARY ANN

No.

The word comes out before she can stop it.

Spencer looks at her.

Mary Ann lowers her eyes, but does not take it back.

William moves between Spencer and the door.

Not aggressively.

Just there.

WILLIAM

Wait.

SPENCER

For what?

William cannot answer.

Then —

A sound outside.

Not horses.

A knock.

One single knock against wood.

Everyone freezes.

Another knock.

Not at the door.

From outside near the shed.

William raises the rifle.

Spencer reaches for his.

John Samuel's eyes widen.

Christopher starts to cry but Mary Ann covers him.

Permelia steps toward the wall, where she can see through a gap.

Silence.

Then a third sound.

A loose shutter tapping in the wind.

William lowers the rifle slowly.

No one laughs.

Nobody is relieved.

Fear has made the house into a trap.

EXT. MODERN WORKSPACE — EVENING

Daniel looks at his notes:

THE LAST ORDINARY DAY

He adds:

ORDINARY SOUNDS BECOME THREATS

DANIEL (V.O.)

A house under threat changes before anyone touches it.

He studies a photograph or map of a homestead area.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Doors stop being doors. Windows stop being windows. A road stops being a road.

A beat.

DANIEL (V.O.)

Everything becomes a question of who can see whom first.

Cut back.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHTFALL

The family prepares for night.

Not sleep.

Night.

Mary Ann folds a blanket over Christopher.

John Samuel sits beside the window, lower now.

William checks the rifle.

Spencer watches him.

SPENCER

You ever think maybe waiting is what they want?

William nods.

WILLIAM

Yes.

SPENCER

And if stepping out is what they want?

WILLIAM

That too.

Spencer lets out a small humorless breath.

SPENCER

Convenient.

WILLIAM

No.

He looks toward the ridge.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

Designed.

That word lands.

Designed.

Not random.

Not fear.

A plan.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD — NIGHTFALL

The riders begin moving.

Slow.

Not toward the house yet.

Along the ridge.

Changing position.

The young rider looks back toward the house.

Jess sees him.

JESS

Don't look like that.

YOUNG RIDER

Like what?

JESS

Like you expect it to look different after.

The young rider says nothing.

Jess rides on.

The auger bumps against his saddle with each step.

Wood and iron.

Borrowed.

Not returned.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

John Samuel hears the faint clink.

Metal on saddle.

He does not know what it is.

But we do.

He whispers toward William:

JOHN SAMUEL

They're moving.

William's head turns.

WILLIAM

How many?

John Samuel listens.

His face tight.

JOHN SAMUEL

More than two.

The room absorbs the number.

More than two means not passing.

More than two means not neighborly.

More than two means morning may come with men already in place.

Spencer stands.

This time no one tells him to sit.

He goes to the door.

Does not open it.

Just stands there.

Listening.

EXT. HORNER HOMESTEAD — NIGHT

The house glows faintly.

Above, in the dark, several riders pass behind trees.

The camera stays wide.

No faces.

No attack.

Just movement.

The land arranging itself around the house.

INT. HORNER HOUSE — NIGHT

The family stands or sits in perfect stillness.

Christopher asleep now, somehow.

Mary Ann's hand rests on his back.

Permelia's eyes are closed but she is not praying.

Spencer at the door.

William beside him.

John Samuel near the window.

Three generations listening to the same threat.

The sound fades.

The silence after is worse.

WILLIAM

They're not coming in the dark.

Spencer looks at him.

SPENCER

You know that?

William listens to the silence.

WILLIAM

No.

A long beat.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

But I think they want us to hear them.

John Samuel says, barely:

JOHN SAMUEL

We did.

No one answers.

CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT TWO.